Emmanuel - 9/14/26, 11:50 AM
Motivation statement: Third ludobiography.

Approaching it in a different way than previous ones. With more intentionality regarding its function into building a library. This production oriented approach may (should?) become a constraint for selecting and working on specific souvenirs. Need to assess the priority if conflict emerges.

I want to reuse some elements that I liked in LB 01 & 02 (what I felt worked well regarding memory processes translation into design mechanics).

- Use of mouse wheel to navigate depth and focus on a memory plane
- Use of an (invisible?) cursor to flesh out the current memory plane

Need to find names and add these mechanics to a repertoire and make them reusable, adaptable. I also want to explore a new idea: the pool, a landscape of some sort (need to go back to Casey and see if there are features that could be translated into mechanics or else).

I was struggling (still am) with the mnemonic content I want to put into play. Some events from my initial diary seemed appropriate but they were triggering. But I can rework my reaction to it. I mean re-associate a triggering image to others that are not. The design process here consists in making some conscious experience (should I say effort?) of mnemonic agency during the game creation and translate it into the very mechanics for this game.

I will use an image that I find upsetting, look for this image in previous memories that are comforting. The game would simply consist in finding this image in a flow of souvenirs. Starting with this image (for now): A hand on my face. Creates different effects depending on who/when/how. Longing. Anxiety. Comfort....

Emmanuel — 9/18/26, 4:18 PM
Diary Update

Lots of thoughts about the look I want for this game.
I'm still happy with the decision to stick to pixel art (for production reasons also) but the sharpness is bothering me.
Thinking of what's happening upon recollection, when I "focus" on something (say, a face), I can obtain a certain degree of sharpness on a specific element but what is around is always fragmentary or blurry . I'm even tempted to fo further and say that it's not "here". It's like I know it's somewhere, floating around what I'm focused on and that I could recollect it, but until I do, it's just a possibility.
I don't remember Casey having a phenomenological description of this specific "feature". Proust may have some stuff along these lines. I want to try and

represent it anyways. With the cursor-movement mechanic probably. A shader would to the work.

Emmanuel — 9/26/26, 9:42 AM
Diary update

Focused on the structure lately while still thinking about the aeshetics and memory content.

I think the structure makes sense (cf commit) Just want to add a notion of cells (mostly a way for me to facilitate the operations on souvenirs) BUT not sure if it needs to be part of the processes (aka prcs_[...]) or a tacite format for content (aka ctt_souvenir).

For the look, after a few shader tests on Pixel Art, I'm starting to thing of ASCII. 3 reasons

- I can *mix* images and text together. I like the blurry line between the two. **When and how does a thought turn into a visual in the mind, and vice versa ?**
- I can better represent the transformation and/or combination (with layers and transparency) of souvenirs
- I liked what I did in Ludobio 02 playing with Font formats to express states of mind

Need to run some tests to confirm direction. For the content itself, the theme transitioned to "Pills" (tied to souvenisr of "hand on face" but easier to represent).

Started listing souvenirs around it and keeping the same idea of finding the *good* ones to *win*.

Emmanuel — 10/2/26, 3:16 PM
Diary update

Been transitionning everything t oACII and kinda happy with the result. It will need some polishing but I think the overall effect of combining text and visuals with the same "material" is an interesting rendering of memory. Also added some random noise (letters changing randomly) in the memory. Like souvenirs that "try" to emerge in background. Needs some polishing but works OK.

Now, while thinking about the Pool I chose (ie. "pills") I found myself thinking in an associationist way. That is, going from one souvenir to another that has ties to it.

Bergson advocates *against* associationist and I initially went with *his* understanding of recollection for my recollection process but I wanna stick to my own experience and, in the case of this Pool at least, that's how I process it.

I'm thinking of keeping the interaction I have for Recollection process (wheel movement) but tweaking it with an associationist perspective: when recollecting, only souvenirs with a direct thematic link to the one I'm focusing on right now can appear. This is either in replacement or in addition to the notion of plane/depth.

The content itself is unfolding little by little the more I think about this pool. Which is precisely the design loop I want to have (for processes too). Deciding to make a game about a memory content or process forces me to think about it and "build" some agency that I then want to provide in the game. Not actually sure of the exact shape of this loop but the important thing is designing "about" it (in the game) helps me design "it" in my head.

Emmanuel — 10/8/26, 5:17 PM
Diary update

Finished working on the different processes while keeping a organization that makes sense with my conception of memory. In the end I decided to keep Recollection and Association separate and I think it works well this way.
Each process has its own interaction (mouse movement, mouse wheel, click) but they work together in a seamless way. I also feel (to be confirmed with testers) that they give a feeling of search/exploration. They are also aesthetically pleasant, in a "toy" way.
I feel though that I may struggle to go past this toy dimension if I continue with what I had in mind for failures / success conditions. It is a bit dull. Going from a souvenir to another and finding the right way is pretty binary. On the other side, I want to keep it quite simple and don't want to add mechanics just for the sake of the game experience. I could go push further the Association process and make it a real deduction/cognitive challenge, like detective games. Or I could push further the manipulation challenges (Clarity and Recollection processes).
None feels 100$ satisfying. Another solution would be to play with the content and make it more ambiguous/hidden, forcing players to really pay attention to it but that puts some pressure on content creation, thus possibly too much workload if I want to finish this project fast enough.
For now I will certainly keep my initial idea just to test it and see where it takes me.

Another small issue I have with the prototype right now is that it's a bit dark. Not playful. I liked the pop colors and cute pixel art I went with for LB 01. It brought some distance to the topic that was a bit heavy (while still, I think, keeping it

relatable). But I think I can play around with my ASCII art to obtain something similar-ish.

Emmanuel — 10/8/26, 5:41 PM
RE prev entry:

Thought about it more and I feel like the gameplay direction should just align with what this specific mnemonic experience does for me. It can NOT be completely agnostic.
ie.

- If I go back in time to understand something > deductive reasoning/ gameplay
- If I look for a memory that it's hard do seize > challenging manipulation
- If I'm looking for interpretation > choices

etc

Emmanuel — 10/13/26, 11:38 AM
Motivation Statement Update

I'm now done with the code part and I'm focusing on the data content. So time to revisit the original statement and see what stayed and what changed.

Library of memory processes
The initial intention for the project was to start building a re-useable library of memory processes.
I kept this direction for most of the project. I started with recycling mechanics from LB01 & LB02. I updated them to work with ASCII art and also added 2 new "processes". This library is not the leading intention for the project anymore (focus shifted when I started working on actual content) but I still try to respect it.
I found myself struggling a bit on what the design should prioritize: philosophical framework OR game potential OR personal experience. For now, I decided that my compass would be my personal experience.

From Pixel art to ASCII.
Think I didn't mention it in the original statement (because it was obvious) but I wanted to keep experimenting with pixel art. But I kept being disappointed with the results (with shaders). At Ludodrome, I saw an ASCII game that stuck with me. When I started transitioning to ASCII art, I reached the effect I was looking for. I need to dedicate some more thinking about the potential of ASCII to depict

mnemonic material (maybe another design diary entry).

Refocusing on self-narration
I knew I wanted to start with an upsetting image and try to find a good souvenir associated to it (and design the same experience for the player). But when I explored my own memories, the original idea (a hand on my face) fell short. I took a step back and started thinking about other souvenirs associated to this image. Thought of pills. It grew more and more important and somehow took the lead in my interest in the project.

What now?
I will just focus on data content in order to finish this project soon and gather feedback. I'm not very satisfied with my success conditions. But like with previous projects, I consider it a starting point for the next project.
I want to:
1. Nail down better my "game" expectations (success, failure, risk, rewards and such...)
2. Keep exploring ASCII art in relation to memory depiction
3. Continue building my library of processes,

Emmanuel — 10/16/26, 2:19 PM
Diary Update

A few things...

Feeling a bit fustrated today as I'm rushadding (yes, rushadding) data to have a first "complete" prototype (which is a good thing) but I see all the design intentions (ie. things I want to do) or problems (ie. things not working but I don't have an answer for it yet) I will address later.

To Do list of improvements:

- Move camera with mouse (and NOT on "click on souvenir" only)
- Blur the line between text and images in the souvenirs
  - This needs a more flexible "grid" and "cells" system
- ASCII editor: need to dedicate more time to either find a more adequate editor or make one
- Individual letter color control (needs the editor)
- Question: not 100% satisfied with my associationist system: Maybe tags? Gut feeling is it may work.
- Question: not satisfied either with success conditions (I expected I wouldn't but wanted to still try it). Been thinking of adding a typing

mechanic (that would work with tags) but would that be too complicated / gamey? I 'd like to keep the simplicity but...
- Question: what to do with the pool limit if I move the camera? loop ? go to other pool (when more content) ? It could be infinite potentially... Which I like. but it wouldn't happen. I need to either simulate it or decide it's just a limited pool.

Tech/pipe big question: I want to keep going with ASCII art for some time and I'm considering transitioning to JS but when? BEFORE addressing the To Do list above? Or AFTER it, for another project ?
I should just wait for feedback (and take a bit of time-distance too) to see how far it's worth pushing it. I like the idea of keeping this project on the side and feeding it with more and more memory content to until it's huge but that's my Proust fanboy persona talking. Or thinking.

Convo with Wiley in my public diary
Wiley — 10/16/26, 2:35 PM
Emmanuel- let's talk about grid/ascii stuff soon, I have recommendations for tools
Emmanuel — 10/16/26, 2:37 PM
yes please !

❓

Emmanuel — 10/17/26, 11:58 AM
Diary Update RE Questions above:

I'm leaning more and more towards the use of tags for association.
I could also add a weight to it to define recollection distance (now based on time but makes no sense).
- EITHER by adding a Text field (more elegant/gamey) BUT it breaks the "chain" logic of my Association process as I could type a tag unrelated to a currently "associating" souvenir...
- OR by displaying and making clickable Tags related to currently "associating" souvenirs . Less fun, but clearer too.

Clicking or typing would have the effect to reveal associated souvenirs (with Recollection distance being related to Tag weight).

TBD

Emmanuel — Yesterday at 10:09 AM
Ending Statement

Some feedback I got

- ASCII aesthetic works well
- Feeling of exploration works
- Bite-sized narrative content and threads helps keep some players engaged
- The fact that it's about Memory (as process) is not obvious
- Feels like diary entries more than a Memory experience
- Fees more like personal (egocentric) diary than a game made for others

I see 3 main questions at the moment that need to be answered.

- What is the game about?
  It's (supposed to be) both about Memory as a Human experience (mechanics), and specific memories as individual (shared/relatable) experiences (text/narrative). But there is a tug of war between these two things. Is there a way to make it work together / reinforce each other ? It works in Proust. Different format for sure but still. Maybe I need to look in detail at how this works. Or look at games that do it well? Maybe To the moon? not sure...

- Can it go beyond personal diary?
  Right now it's quite egocentric and not really engaging for players. The reference I have in mind in terms of balance between personal experience and player engagement is Dys4ia but here the mecanics are much more tied to the lived experiences. Whereas in my case I make memory playable but the experiences are only described. Is that why it's less engaging (at least as a game)?

- What should failure / success look like in a ludobiography?
  I know I want to get out of ineffectual agency. Right now it's mostly free exploration though. I have ideas to make it closer to players' expectations (that is more gamey) but need to experiment with it. Also, following convo with Richy, I wonder if the Appropriation mechanic should be back and made more central?

- Side question: Can I include the diaru about the game as part of the game ?
  Not a problem in itself but it could solve some problems (?). Or help read the game in a certain way. I'm also thinking of artists that follow a daily creation algorithm (Opalka, Kawara) and wonder if there is something to explore here...

Emmanuel — 10:05 AM
Ending Statement Bis

Pippin's feedback:

- **What will be the final structure ?**
- The idea right now is to keep the Association mechanics (still tree-like then) but I also want to add a Tag Research mechanic (similar to Her Story). And the two may conflict OR complexity the experience. I also want clearer Association goals.
  3D space would NOT work with my Recollection mechanic (the mouse wheel) I think. And it also presents Memory as a 3D space, which I don't experience this way (?). Loci / relative positions yes, but not a 3D space.

- **Language patterns and memory structure ?**
  Yes! I My view is that language itself is a natural expression of the way we think (//Chomsky ?... I've never read him...). So some language patterns would necessarily match memory ones (even out of language-structured thinking). Need to read some structuralism.

- **Poetic commits has little value as research material**
  I tend to agree but I wanna push it a bit more (the last commits were not *serious* enough about it). It still helps me to be reflective in a different way. I *need* a different approach in commits for them to be useful to me (as well as research material). What about a reflection of my *feelings* at the moment of commit. Not on the *content*, but on how I *experienced the content-creation*?